

Dvar Torah Outline — Hallel (Tehillim 118): Hoda'ah as Hashlamah and Deveikut; Three Groups and the Name "יה" That Expands the Meitzar ה"ה

Abstract

This dvar Torah (based on the Maharal's approach) develops the idea that הודאה is not merely saying "thank you," but a form of תשלומים—"repayment" through giving oneself back to Hashem, which creates דבקות. It explains why Hallel singles out three groups—ישראל, בית אהרן, and יראי ה'—first as recipients of distinct חסדים, and then more deeply as possessing distinct modes of דבקות. The derash then moves to "מן המצר קראתי יְהוָה," using Midrash to show that the Divine Name invoked shapes the form of the response, and that the Name יְהוָה specifically embodies *merchav*—expansion—because "בְּיָהוָה צֹר עוֹלָמִים."

I. Context: Continuing Hallel and the return to the "three groups"

A. Place in Hallel

- The shiur continues in Hallel around the opening refrain:
 - "הודו לה' כי טוב כי לעולם חסדו" (Give thanks to Hashem for He is good, for His kindness is eternal.)

B. Previously established theme: תשלומים as הודאה

- is framed as תשלומים הודאה—the only "repayment" possible when one recognizes everything is from Hashem.
- The "payback" is **self-completion toward Hashem**: acknowledging dependence and returning oneself to the Source.

C. The three groups reappear

- The chapter addresses three constituencies:
 - ישראל
 - בית אהרן

◦ יראי ה'

- The question being revisited: Why does Hallel specify different groups if the core message is simply "הודו לה'?"

II. First explanation: Different חסדים for different relationships

A. Why חסד differs by group

- ישראל receive חסד "בפני עצמו" because they are **בנים**—children of Hashem.
 - The חסד stems from an essential parent-child bond.
- בית אהרן receive unique חסדים because they are **אוהבי ה'**—a relationship of love.
- יראי ה' receive unique חסדים because of **יראה**—a relationship defined by awe.

B. Why the psalm begins with a universal "הודו"

- First: an all-inclusive הודאה that applies to everyone—before distinctions.
- Even if the חסדים are not equal (**אף על גב שאין החסדים שווים**), all are equal in this: חסד demands הודאה.

C. A side clarification: why no "בית לוי" here

- The shiur contrasts this psalm with places where **בית הלוי** is mentioned (associated with **מידת (הדין)**).
- Here the focus is **חסדים / הטבה**, so the "din-identity" group is not foregrounded.
- **יראת שמים** is framed (via Berachot's principle) as aligned with **מלכות**:
 - "הכל בידי שמים חוץ מיראת שמים" (Everything is in Heaven's hands except fear of Heaven).

III. Deeper explanation: דבקות creates הודאה, and each group has a different דבקות

A. "ועוד יש לך לדעת" — moving from an additional point to a deeper layer

- "ועוד" = another proof/angle.
- "ועוד יש לך לדעת" = a deeper principle you *must know*.

B. The core move: הודאה = hashlamah → deveikut

- הודאה is described as:
 - “השלמות אליו יתברך”—completing oneself toward Hashem.
- That completion is itself דבקות:
 - when a person admits all is from Hashem, the person is “re-attached” to the Source.

C. Creation as “separation,” הודאה as “return”

- The shiur describes a creation-arc:
 - creation looks like becoming נפרד (separate)
 - → reverses that: it reconnects existence back to Hashem דבקות הודאה

D. לכן: each being has its own mode of deveikut

- “וכל נמצא לפי מה שהוא מדריגתו יש לו דבקות בו יתברך.”
- Therefore each “נמצא” has its own proper הודאה:
 - “ולפיכך יש לכל נמצא הודאה... בפני עצמו.”

E. Why the three groups now become necessary even if חסד were “the same”

- First explanation: different חסדים → different הודאות.
- Second (deeper) explanation:
 - even if the חסדים were equal, the **result** of הודאה differs:
 - different groups reach different forms of דבקות.

IV. The structure of כלל → ישראל → בית אהרן → יראי ה'

A. כלל העולם: a general deveikut

- first: the world as a whole has a general connection to Hashem “...לה'”

B. ישראל: deveikut as “children,” and the theme of unity

- have deveikut because they are בני ישראל—like a son attached to a father:
 - “כמו בן שהוא מצטרף אל האב”
- The pasuk is read as singular:
 - “יאמר נא ישראל” (singular language), because the bond is rooted in an essential oneness.

C. ישראל סבא: unity through Yaakov Avinu

- Midrashic layer: “ישראל” alludes to **ישראל סבא** (Yaakov).
- When כלל ישראל are **מתאגדים ומתאחדים**, they become one entity, enabled by Yaakov who unites his sons.

D. “It takes one to know one” — unity enables declaring Hashem’s unity

- The shiur’s phrase: to affirm **Hashem’s oneness**, Israel must be **one**.
- The supporting Gemara reference (idea recalled in the shiur):
 - the שבטים declare “שמע ישראל” to Yaakov, expressing unity of heart and faith.

E. בית אהרן: deveikut from love, and therefore plural language fits

- “**יאמרו נא בית אהרן**” (plural) aligns with love as a broad spectrum of דסח-expressions.
- Love-based service produces a different deveikut than child-based identity.

F. יראי ה': deveikut from awe; yirah as the concluding “seal”

- יראה is presented as the final category—a “חותם.”
- It represents a distinct stance of deveikut, not reducible to דסח/identity.

V. Transition to “מִן הַמִּצָּר” and the Midrash on Divine Names

A. The pasuk

- “**מִן הַמִּצָּר קָרָאתִי יְהוָה עֲנֵנִי בְמִרְחֵב יְהוָה**.”
 - (From the straits I called to Yah; He answered me with expansiveness—Yah.)

B. Midrashic principle: the Name used in prayer shapes the response

- “**בְּכָל שֵׁם שֶׁהֵם קוֹרְאִים לַהֲקָדוֹשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא הֵם נִעֲנִים**.”
 - (With whatever Name they call Hashem, they are answered correspondingly.)
- Examples given:
 - Calling with **אֱלֹהֵי שְׂדֵי** leads to an answer in that mode.
 - Calling with **אלוקים** leads to an answer in that mode.

C. Application to our pasuk

- When one calls specifically with י־ה, one is answered specifically with י־ה:
 - the response matches the invoked Name and its כוח.
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VI. Why the Name י־ה is “בְּיָהּ ה' צֹר” עולמים

A. Names as modes of Hashem’s hanhagah (not “parts” of Hashem)

- Hashem has no limitations; Names are for *our* grasp of His actions—מידות/כוחות.

B. י־ה as the Name of creation and spaciousness

- The explanation hinges on the verse:
 - “כִּי בְיָהּ ה' צֹר עוֹלָמִים.” (For with Yah—Hashem—He formed worlds.)
- Since this Name is associated with creating/ordering worlds:
 - at that “blueprint level” there is proper מקום for everything.
 - therefore it is the Name that **expands** constriction.

C. “Meitzar” as a zero-sum clash over space

- The shiur defines “צר” as when two entities compete for the same מקום.
- Examples used:
 - Haman as “צָרָר הַיְּהוּדִים”—his expansion means our constriction.
 - Co-wives called צרות—one’s closeness displaces the other.

D. The פתרון: appeal to the blueprint-Maker

- When reality feels like “two fighting for one spot,” calling to י־ה is calling to the level where creation already has “room for everyone.”
 - לכן:
 - “מִן הַמֵּצָר קִרְאתִי יְה” → the correct Name for constriction
 - “עֲנֵנִי בַמֵּרְחֵב יְה” → the response is expansion through that same Name
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VII. In Summary

- Hallel’s three groups are not repetitive; they map distinct relationships to Hashem (childhood, love, awe) and therefore distinct חסדים and/or distinct דבקייות.

- **הודאה** is not etiquette but ontology: a “repayment” that returns the self to its Source and creates **דבקות**.
- ;teaches that prayer is answered through the Divine Name invoked **י־ה”מֵן הַמִּצֵּר”** is the Name that transforms **צר** into **מרחב** because it represents the creative order where there is room for all.